



OFFICIAL EXAMINATION OVERVIEW

BCS General Guidelines

Bangladesh Civil Service Examination — structure, eligibility, syllabus and preparation guide

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1. What Is the BCS Examination?

The **Bangladesh Civil Service (BCS) Examination** is the country's principal competitive examination for recruitment into the civil service, conducted by the **Bangladesh Public Service Commission (BPSC)**. It fills posts across the **Generalist (Administrative)** cadres and the **Technical / Professional** cadres, and is widely regarded as one of the most competitive examinations in the country, drawing lakhs of applicants for a few thousand posts each cycle.

The examination runs in three sequential stages — each stage acts as a filter, and only candidates who clear one stage are eligible to sit the next.

2. Examination Structure

Stage	Format	Typical Marks
Preliminary (MCQ)	Objective, multiple-choice, single sitting, 200 questions	200
Written	Subjective / essay-type papers over several days	900 (General) / varies by cadre
Viva Voce	Personality test / interview before the Commission	200

How the stages connect

- The Preliminary result is qualifying only — its marks are not added to the final merit list
- Only candidates who pass the Preliminary sit the Written exam
- Only candidates who pass the Written exam are called for the Viva
- Final merit = Written marks + Viva marks

3. Eligibility Criteria

Nationality & Age

- Must be a citizen of Bangladesh by birth
- Age typically between **21 and 30 years** on the closing date of applications for general candidates (relaxation is normally allowed for freedom fighters' children, physically-challenged, and certain ethnic-minority candidates, as specified in the circular)

Educational Qualification

- At minimum, a Bachelor's degree (Honours) or equivalent from a recognised university
- Some technical/professional cadres (e.g. Health, Engineering) require a specific professional degree such as MBBS, BDS, or a relevant Bachelor of Engineering

Physical & Character Requirements

- Sound health and fitness as certified by the prescribed medical board (post-selection)
- No criminal record; must be of good moral character

- Must not have been dismissed from any government or autonomous body service

4. Cadre Categories

BCS posts are grouped into two broad categories:

Category	Examples of Cadres
Generalist (Administrative)	Administration, Police, Foreign Affairs, Customs & Excise, Taxation, Audit & Accounts, Ansar
Technical / Professional	Health, Education (College/General/Technical), Engineering, Agriculture, Information, Family Planning, Fisheries, Livestock, Forest, Statistics

Candidates rank their cadre preferences on the application. Final cadre allocation depends on merit position, seat availability and preference order — Administration and Foreign Affairs are traditionally the most sought after.

5. Preliminary Exam — Subject-wise Marks

Subject	Marks
Bangla	35
English	35
Bangladesh Affairs	30
International Affairs	20
General Science	15
Computer & Information Technology	15
Mathematical Reasoning	15
Mental Ability	15
Geography, Environment & Disaster Management	10
General Knowledge on Good Governance & Moral Values	10
Total	200

Negative marking usually applies to wrong answers in the Preliminary MCQ — check the current year's circular for the exact deduction ratio.

6. Written Examination

Written papers differ by cadre choice. Candidates for **Generalist cadres** sit a common set of compulsory papers plus optional subjects; candidates for **Technical/Professional cadres** sit papers relevant to their discipline plus a reduced set of general papers.

Typical compulsory papers (General cadre)

- Bangla (1st & 2nd paper)
- English (1st & 2nd paper)
- Bangladesh Affairs
- International Affairs
- Mathematical Reasoning & Mental Ability
- General Science & Technology

Optional subjects

Candidates additionally choose optional subjects related to their academic background or cadre preference (e.g. Political Science, Economics, Public Administration, Accounting, or a relevant engineering/science subject), each carrying its own paper(s).

7. Viva Voce (Interview)

The final stage is a personality assessment before a Commission board. It evaluates communication, general awareness, subject knowledge, and suitability for public service — not just rote knowledge.

- Carry the original and photocopies of all academic certificates, NID, and admit card
- Dress formally; arrive well ahead of the scheduled time
- Expect questions on your academic background, cadre choices, current affairs, and the reasoning behind them
- Stay calm, honest, and consistent — the board values clarity of thought over memorised answers

8. General Exam-Day Instructions

- 1 Bring the **original Admit Card** and a valid **National ID / equivalent photo ID** — no entry without both
- 2 Arrive at the venue at least 30–60 minutes before the reporting time
- 3 Mobile phones, smart watches, calculators, and any electronic device are strictly prohibited inside the exam hall
- 4 Use only a black ball-point pen for the OMR sheet unless the circular specifies otherwise
- 5 Follow invigilators' instructions on seating, OMR filling, and timing without exception
- 6 Do not mark or write anything other than what is instructed on the OMR sheet — stray marks can void the sheet
- 7 Malpractice of any kind leads to immediate disqualification and possible legal action

9. Preparation Strategy

Suggested timeline

Phase	Focus
Months 1–3	Build fundamentals: complete syllabus overview, core Bangla/English grammar, basic Bangladesh & international affairs
Months 4–7	Subject-wise depth: General Science, Computer & ICT, Math & Mental Ability, daily current affairs
Months 8–10	Preliminary-focused revision: timed MCQ practice, past question analysis, weak-area drilling
Post-Preliminary	Shift to Written syllabus depth and essay/answer-writing practice for chosen optional subjects

General tips

- Follow one standard reference book per subject rather than switching frequently between sources
- Practice at least 8–10 years of previous BCS Preliminary questions under timed conditions
- Read a national newspaper daily and keep concise notes on current affairs (national + international)
- Join or form a small study group for regular discussion and answer review
- For the Written stage, practice full-length answer writing, not just reading — examiners score presentation and structure too
- Take periodic full-length mock tests to build exam-day stamina and time management

Key Takeaways

Remember these before you start

- Three stages — Preliminary (qualifying) → Written → Viva; only Written + Viva marks count toward merit
- Check eligibility (age, education, nationality) carefully before applying
- Choose cadre preferences thoughtfully — allocation follows merit and seat availability
- Preliminary rewards breadth and speed; Written rewards depth and structured writing
- Always verify current-year details against the official BPSC circular before acting

Disclaimer: Marks distribution, cadre lists and rules follow the pattern most recently used by the Bangladesh Public Service Commission (BPSC) and are provided as a general study reference. BPSC updates circulars, syllabi and quotas from time to time — always cross-check the current details against the official BPSC circular at **bpsc.gov.bd** and the Bangladesh Gazette before applying or sitting for the exam.